

ANCIENT NEAR EASTERN STUDIES

SUPPLEMENT 19

ARCHAEOLOGY IN SOUTHERN CAUCASUS: PERSPECTIVES FROM GEORGIA

Edited by

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PEETERS

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A MIDDLE BRONZE AGE BURIAL AT ATSURI

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The Atsquri barrow is situated in the valley of the same name, on the left bank of the Mtkvari (Kura) River, Akhaltsikhe district (Fig. 1). This stone mound, which contained a mass burial in a pit grave, dating to the end of the Middle Bronze Age, was discovered after it had been damaged during work on the farmstead owned by N. and G. Gasitashvili. The Atsquri Expedition, directed by V. Licheli, carried out archaeological excavations at the site in July 2001.¹ An anatomical analysis of the human bones indicates that 63 individuals — 21 adult males, 38 adult females, and 4 juveniles — were buried in the grave and suggests that we are dealing with the resting place of an extended family.

Prior to excavation, a grid covering an area 4.5×4.6 m was established to divide the barrow into four parts. Shortly after work began, a mushroom-headed pin and fragments of black pottery were found within the cobblestone shell 10–15 cm below the vegetation layer that covered the mound. This depth is equivalent to 1.2 m below the site's datum point. Cleaning revealed the burial to have a circular configuration about 3.8 m in diameter. Following the complete removal of the stones, sherds of black cups and pots, as well as parts of a human skeleton, were found mixed together (Figs 2–5). Owing to the central part of the barrow being considerably damaged, the bones were concentrated along the central and western sides of the trench. Five human skulls were discernible in the mixed mass. The concentration of bones was spread over a fairly large area: 2.89 (north-south) $\times$ 2.53 m (east-west). The depth of

¹ The bulk of the work was financed by the family of G. and A. Boswells (USA), and is acknowledged with deep gratitude.

this concentration from the datum varied little — 1.65 cm (the south part), 1.53 cm (the north part), and 1.65 cm (the central section). Parts of broken bronze daggers and disc-headed pins were also found at this level. Bones of the lower limbs, lying above two severely deformed skulls, were found beneath the western section of the mound. Here the cluster of bones was much more compact: to the east lay a skull, a thigh bone, a pot (25 cm from the skull), and several fragments of a bronze dagger.

In the southern part of the deposit, under the bones of the deceased, and at a depth of 2.09 m beneath the datum, were found a one-handed cup, a bronze disc-headed pin and an ornamented gold disc with a diameter of 4.5 cm. The edges of the disc are folded back and perforated with two holes, with a trace of a thin bronze plate on its reverse side. Black pottery sherds were found next to the disc. The deceased appear to have been laid on a bed that itself was placed over the pottery. Although no trace of wooden material has survived, the loose brown soil at this point suggests that the funerary bier was made from wood or some form of matting. A spherical-headed pin lay 20 cm to the west of the disc, and to its north was placed a tanged dagger. The skeleton of an ox (length 1.85 m) was found mixed with human bones at this point. On the same level in Square A, at its northern corner, lay two human skulls facing south-east. Three pyramidal-headed bronze pins had survived *in situ* on one of the skulls (lying to the south), clearly pointing to their use as hairpins. Two, square and perforated bronze plaques lay in front of the face and were presumably attached to the clothes. A dagger, with a bronze bracelet lying above it, lay at the eastern edge of the trench (Square B2). A large disc-headed pin, a torque, and a deer skull with antlers were found at the boundary between squares A1 and B1 at a depth of 1.93 m. Small carnelian beads were found under the torque. The beads were mixed with ornamented gold sheaths in the shape of thin tubes. Presumably these items were the component parts of a pendant. To the east of the pin was a dagger with two nails surviving on the tang.

Parts of a human skeleton were discovered at the centre of Square A2. Two daggers were found here, not *in situ*, and four bronze discoid pins were recovered from the chest area. At the same level, in Square A1, a very loose brownish earth strip (width 3.5 cm, length ca. 1.87 cm) was cleaned, clearly differing from the surrounding earth in consistency and colour. It appears that some organic item was placed here, perhaps a board that lay at the north wall of the chamber. In the same square, at the western wall of the chamber, a black-clay two-handled mug (*kantharos*) was recovered. About 60 cm eastwards, fragments of another two-handled mug came to light. In the south-west corner lay a large bronze disc-headed pin, a torque, beads of carnelian and gold, and a bronze dagger with two nails and tang. Here fragments of two bronze discs were also found, their artistic image similar to that of the gold discs — a centred dot surrounded by several rows of relief concentric circles and punch ornament. An oval bronze pendant, with decorative relief circles, was found in the southeast corner of Square A1. Next to it, 60 cm to the west, lay two badly corroded bronze discs (4.5 cm

in diameter), resembling the above-mentioned design, and from the southwest corner of the same square came another gold disc, with several carnelian beads around it. This concentration of *in situ* objects was placed around the neck or chest of one of the deceased. Seventeen arrowheads with grooved shafts (16 of obsidian and one of flint) were found *in situ* (Square A, western part of chamber). The thin, dark-coloured layer in which they were deposited differs in consistency and colour, leading to the assumption that the arrowheads had been placed in a quiver, though we cannot determine from what material the quiver was manufactured (leather, or perhaps some coarse fabric). A tanged dagger, and above it a massive bracelet, were also found here.

It should be specially noted that a thin layer (2.4 × 2.4 m in area) — also dark in hue — was cleaned on the floor of the chamber, to its south. To the west of this layer, against the wall, lay two human skulls and part of the limb of a bovid (possibly an ox). The pottery at this level — in squares A1, A2 and B2 — is concentrated in three groups. Typologically, the vessels within the three groups are quite diverse, thereby preventing a meaningful seriation. However, in most cases their *in situ* discovery suggests that in order to bury the last deceased, pottery was moved from the central and northern half of the chamber. This would also explain why the central part contains bronze items only. The distribution of items may also suggest that one of the pottery groups (presumably the pottery of squares B2–A2) — a pot with knobs, a mug, a jar with five handles, as well as the metal items attested in the western part of the chamber — belonged to the last deposition.

The floor of the chamber was reached at a depth of 2 m from the datum point, with no clear trace of any dromos. However, there is a row of stones (1.1 m wide) in the southern part of the chamber that may be connected with the entrance. Here a sterile layer of gravel also appears at the chamber's floor level. The last item on the floor, and the lowest in the northwest corner of the chamber, was a bronze conical-headed pin.

In total the Atsquri burial contained 54 hand-made clay vessels, including jars, pots, mugs, cups, and drinking vessels (Figs 11–19). Pots are either well polished (black), or lightly polished (greyish-brownish, blackish-brownish, black, grey, and blackish-greyish). They have a smooth surface and a hard, gritty fabric. Three pots have handles, whereas one has five miniature handles running around the shoulder. Knobs attached on the upper body are the usual form of decoration, though occasionally represented together with polished, grooved and punctate ornamentation. One vessel bears a crudely depicted face (Fig. 14: 2). Two one-handled pots bear grooved and stamped ornaments. On one of these pots two small conical knobs are applied opposite the handle. Two small pots were brought to light in the burial: one is greyish-brownish and asymmetrical, crudely modeled from a gritty fabric with white admixtures, and has nine conical pellets below the mouth; the other, a one-handled pot, is poorly polished, and made from a compact clay.

Eight cups of various forms were found in the burial and are in the same colour range as the pots. Rounded in profile, they can have up to two handles, occasionally

rising above the mouth. They are made mostly from hard clay, containing sand and fine white, occasionally shining, admixture. Such drinking-cups have a plain inner surface, though occasionally they are smoothed. Three cups from the burial are asymmetric, whereas one fine cup stands apart for its black, mirror-like, polish.

Ten one-handled mugs, differing in form and ornament, have also been found: six are plain; three have a grooved ornament running around the body; and one has a flat projection adorned with a stamped ornament on the opposite side to the handle. Four mugs found are manufactured from a solid clay, containing sand and fine white admixture. One is black and polished like a mirror, whereas three grayish-brownish mugs are poorly polished. Inner surfaces are mostly smoothed. The base of one black-polished mug is concave and has a 'window' of obsidian set into it. This mug is adorned with a grooved ornament applied on a dull background.

A large number of metal artefacts were found in the burial, including 221 bronze items. Among these were 11 weapons: a spearhead, nine daggers and a double-pronged fork (Figs 6–10). The open-socket spearhead has two nail holes for nails to fix it to the shaft. Daggers come in a variety of forms, with and without a tang. Two daggers have a grooved line along both sides of the rib, and another has a relief line. Some have up to three nail holes, some with attached nails. Bronze jewellery include 132 pins subdivided into 14 types according to the form of the head (Fig. 6): conical (5); pyramidal, with bosses (7); pyramidal (27), with a round head and four soldered knobs (1) umbrella-like (18); disc-shaped, both large- (6) and small-sized (52); spherical (2); hemispherical (5); and featuring a carnelian bead (1). All these have a perforation in the shank. Five other types are not perforated: volute (1); hook-like (1), loop-like (2), and loop-like with the tip of the curved head turned outward (1).

Among other bronze personal ornaments are 29 bracelets, falling into three forms (Figs 6–7): with the ends touching each other (5), penannular (14), and with overlapping ends (7). The rods of most of the bracelets are rounded on the above exterior and flat on the inner side. There are also bracelets with a round cross-section. Here, the rod is largely thickened in the middle, and slightly thinned and flattened at the ends. Three bracelets are formed of a rod of thin wire, and are so damaged as to preclude reconstruction. Bracelets have no ornament. One bracelet with overlapping ends has a rib on the back and inner surface. Seven torques were also among the grave goods: five of these are similar to one another — with a round cross-section rod and its end turned upward (Fig. 8: 4). Another (Fig. 8: 5) is twisted in the middle, with a round cross-section rod and flat end curving outward. Only a fragment of the seventh torque survives.

Note should be taken of an oval pendant (Fig. 7: 8) with a hook and four decorative centre-dot circles. We are unaware of such a pendant elsewhere. Another bronze pendant is of triangular shape, with a flat cross-section rod, and overlapping ends. Of the four spirals, three have a round cross section. A fine wire ring with overlapping ends, hemispherical appliqué with a single hole at the edge (12), quadrangular

plaques with projecting dots (2), and 'handles' presumably used as fasteners (Fig. 7: 14–15), are also part of the repertoire. Only the bracelets and a figurine of a dog (Fig. 7: 5) are cast in bronze; the rest of the bronze artefacts are hammered.

Some of the deceased were buried with gold. Eighteen items made of thin (0.01 cm) gold plate were found. Three discs (Fig. 9: 1–3) executed with high degree of skill are noteworthy. These have a dot in the middle and are surrounded by relief concentric circles and several rows of punctate ornament. The edges of the discs are folded back; one has bronze lining on its back; and on another, one hole is made on opposite sides. Nine perforated, gold, tubular sheathings decorated with grooves formed part of necklace (Fig. 9: 5–6). Another necklace had gold beads (3) (Fig. 9: 5), one of which is composed of three, conjoined pomegranate-shaped beads. A spiral-shaped bead and two plain plaques were also made of gold.

Two hundred and eighty-six beads of various shapes and mostly carved from carnelian, come in a range of colours — dark and light hues, transparent and opaque. A few faience beads were also found, including an Egyptian faience bead, turquoise in colour. Pendants (Fig. 8: 34, 37–39) also show diversity in shapes. Shell (Fig. 7: 11) and artefacts manufactured from cattle horn were also used in jewellery making. A few household artefacts were also deposited. These include three hemispherical, bone spindle whorls (Fig. 7: 13), and a mortar (Fig. 19: 7) and pestle (Fig. 19: 6). One flint and seventeen obsidian arrowheads (Fig. 10: 12–13) are particularly noteworthy for their fine flaking techniques. The obsidian ranges from black to transparent.

The Atsquri burial belongs to the Trialeti culture and as such should be dated to the end of the Middle Bronze Age, around 1600–1500 BC. It is noteworthy for several reasons. First, is the practice of mass burial, as opposed to a multiple burial with several individuals only, which raises interesting question about the social system of the community involved. Second, while most of the grave goods have local parallels, a number are indicative of contacts with more distant lands. These include the pot featuring a representation of the human face, the *kantharos*-like vessel, the tall-handled bowl, bronze weapons, pins, gold discs, and beads and pendants made of various stone types and minerals. Third, the grave goods from Atsquri are noteworthy for the high level of craftsmanship. Whether metal objects or stone tools, ceramics or beads, most of the items deposited with the deceased are very well made. Finally, and related to the effort invested in the manufacture of the grave goods, one must consider the wealth represented at Atsquri and, in turn, the social and ritual implications of disposing of such wealth.

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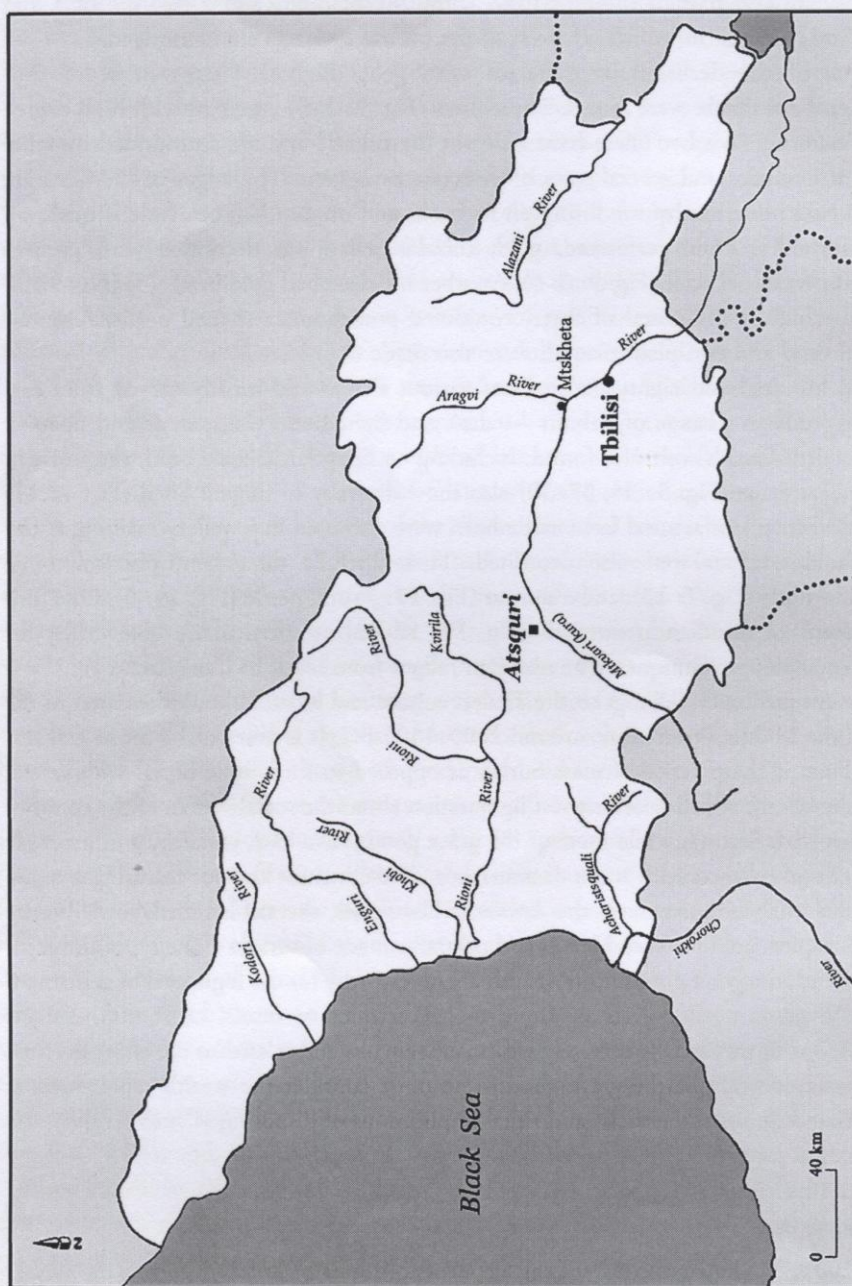


Fig. 1: Map showing the location of Atsquri.

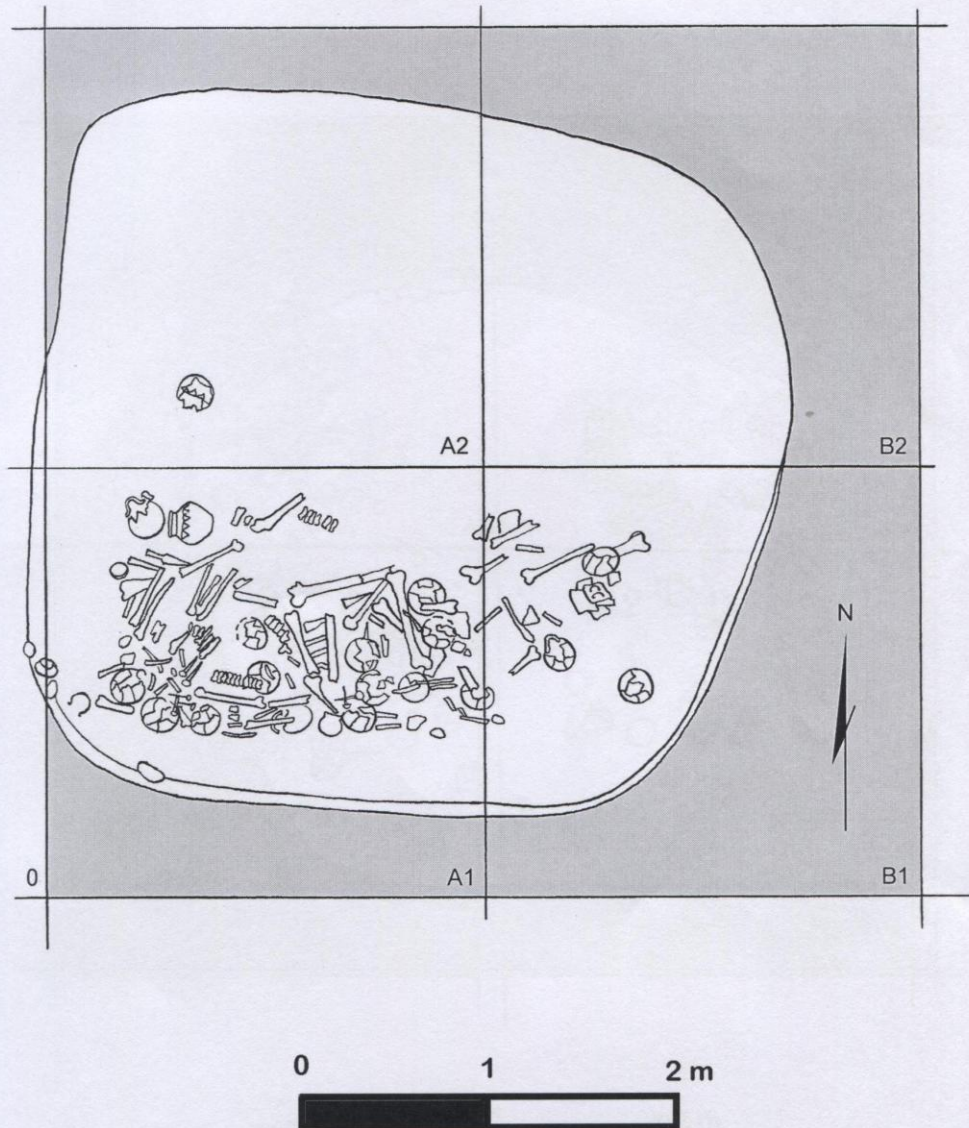


Fig. 2: Atsquri, upper level of the tomb deposit.

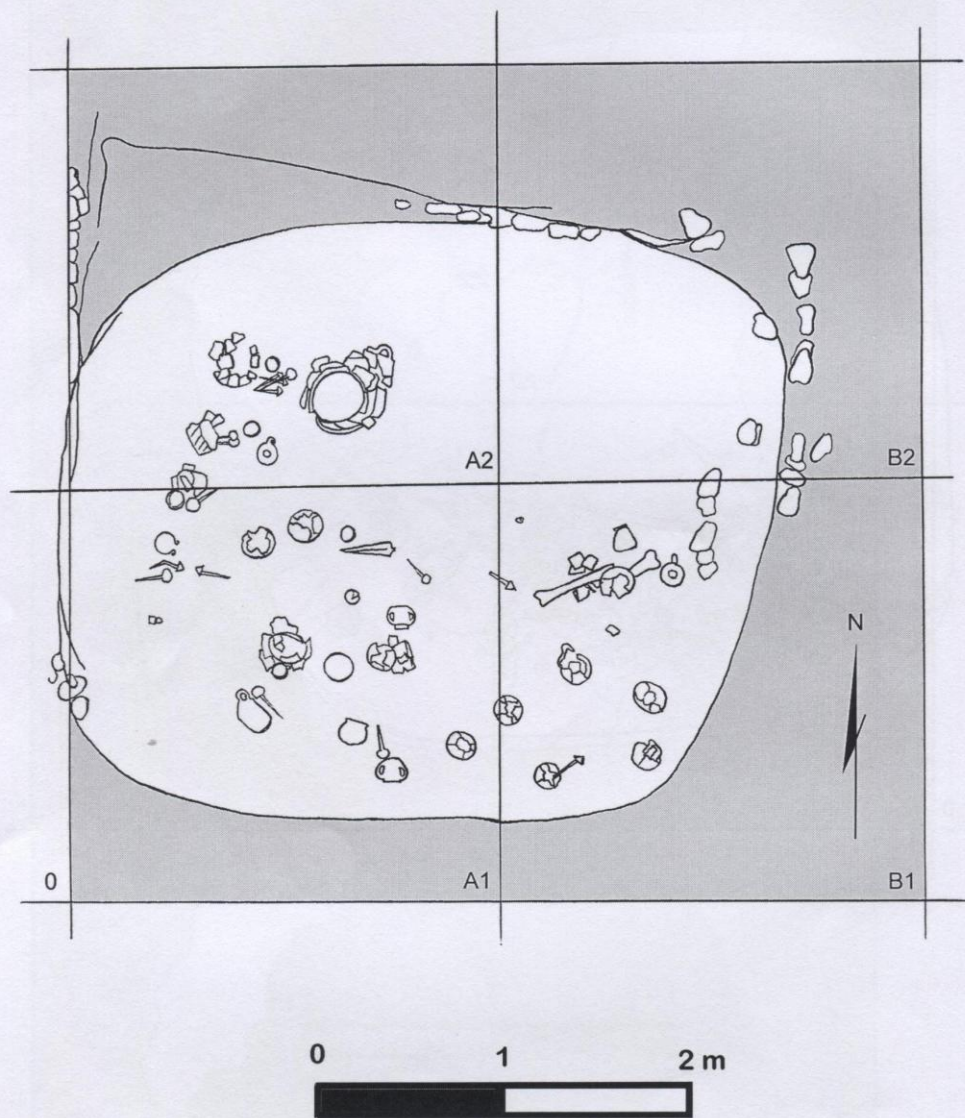


Fig. 3: Atsquri, middle level of the tomb deposit.

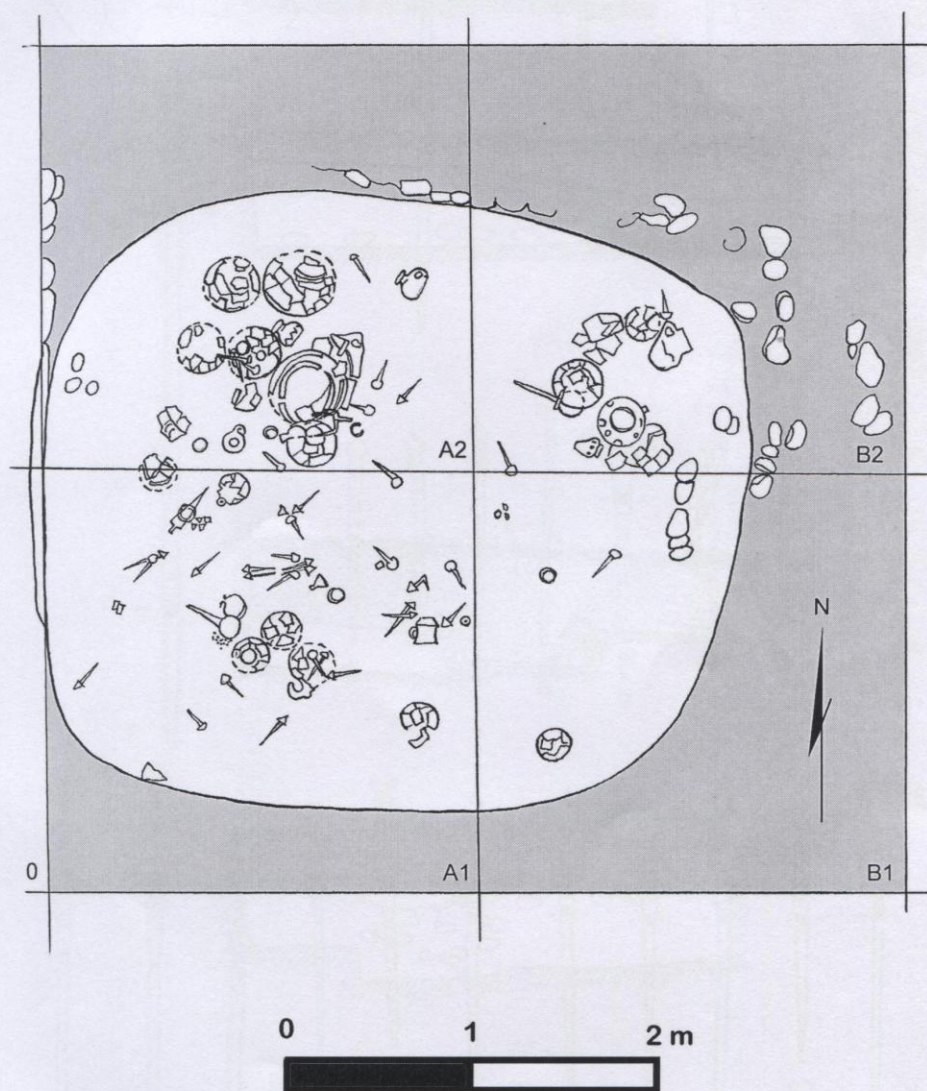


Fig. 4: Atsquri, lower level of the tomb deposit.

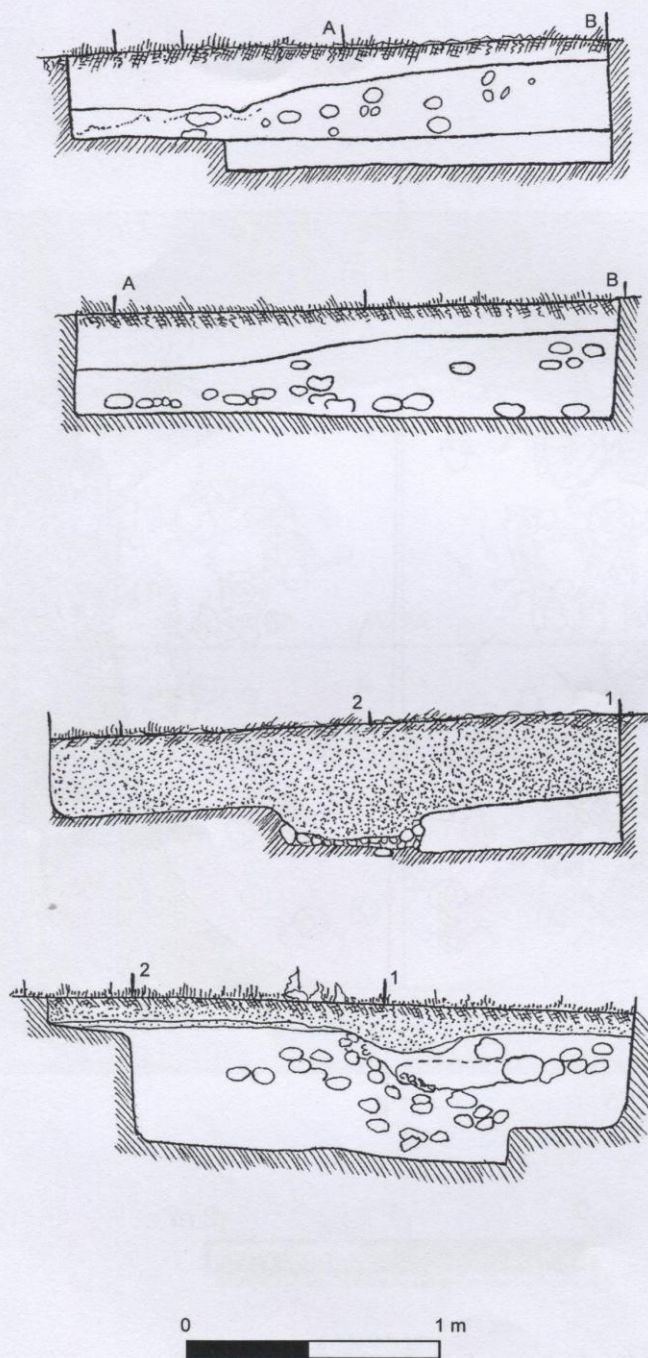


Fig. 5: Atsquri, cross-section of the burial pit.

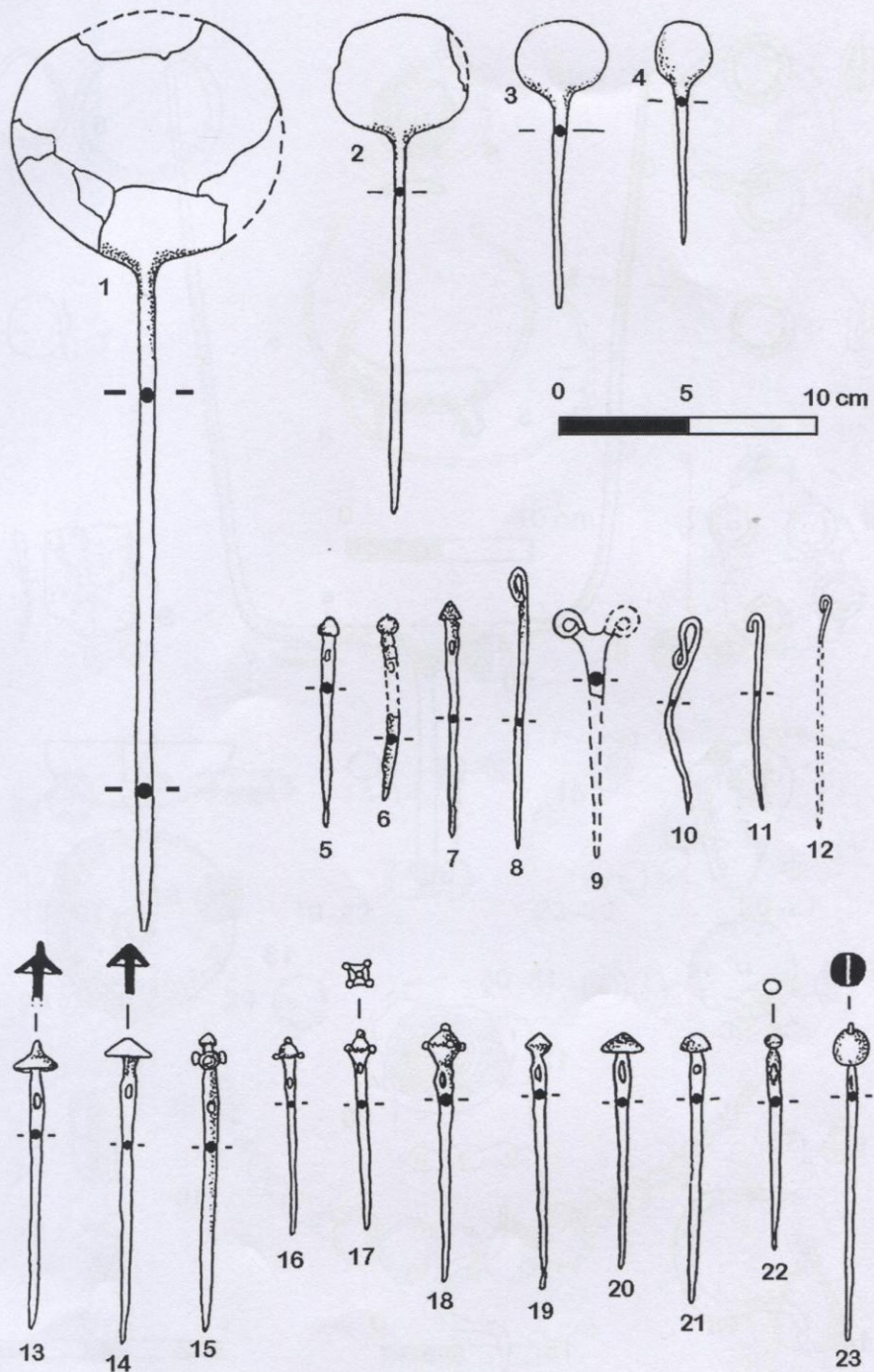


Fig. 6: Bronze pins from the Atsquri barrow.

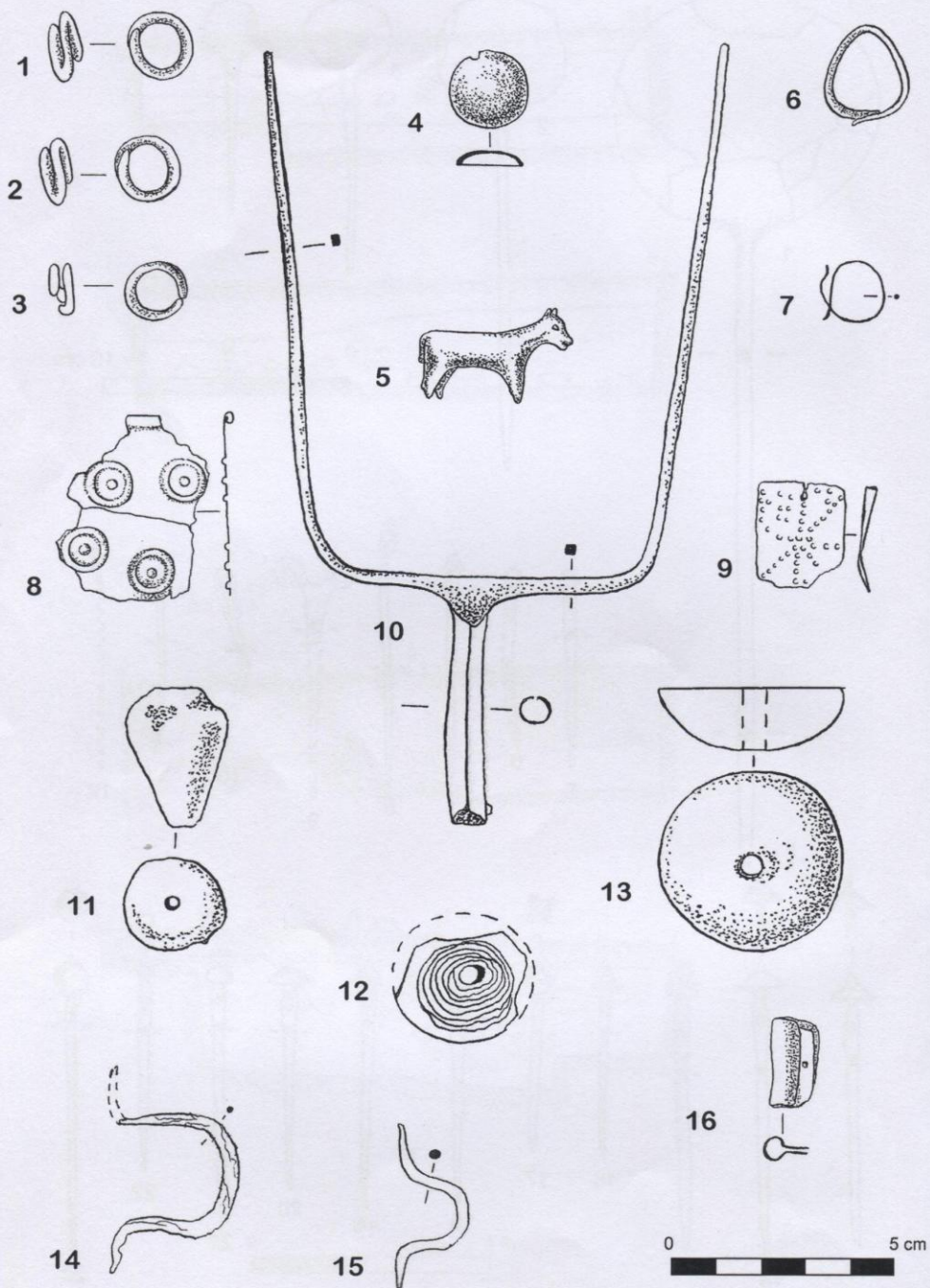


Fig. 7: Various objects from the Atsquri barrow. All are bronze except for 11 (shell) and 13 (bone).

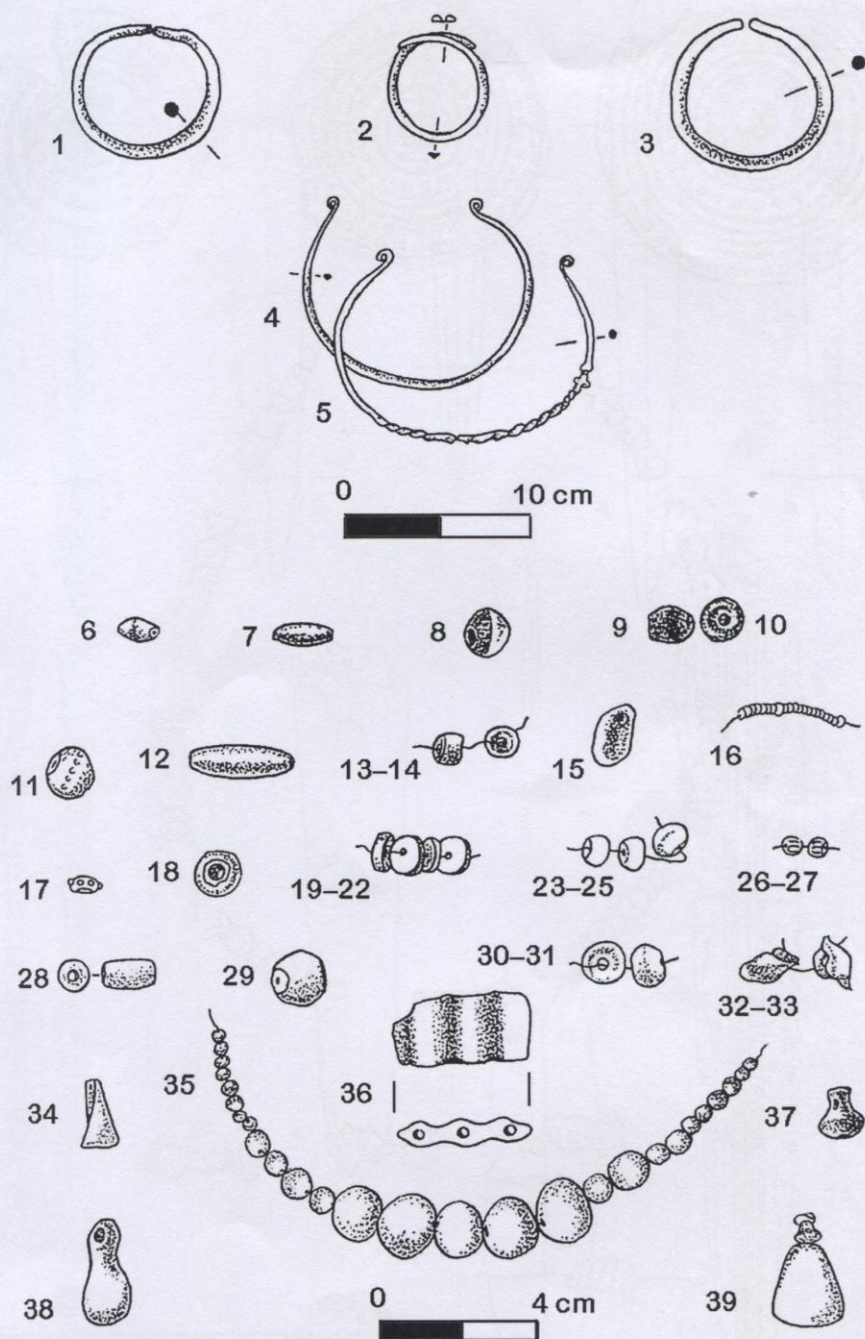


Fig. 8: Jewellery from the Atsquri barrow.

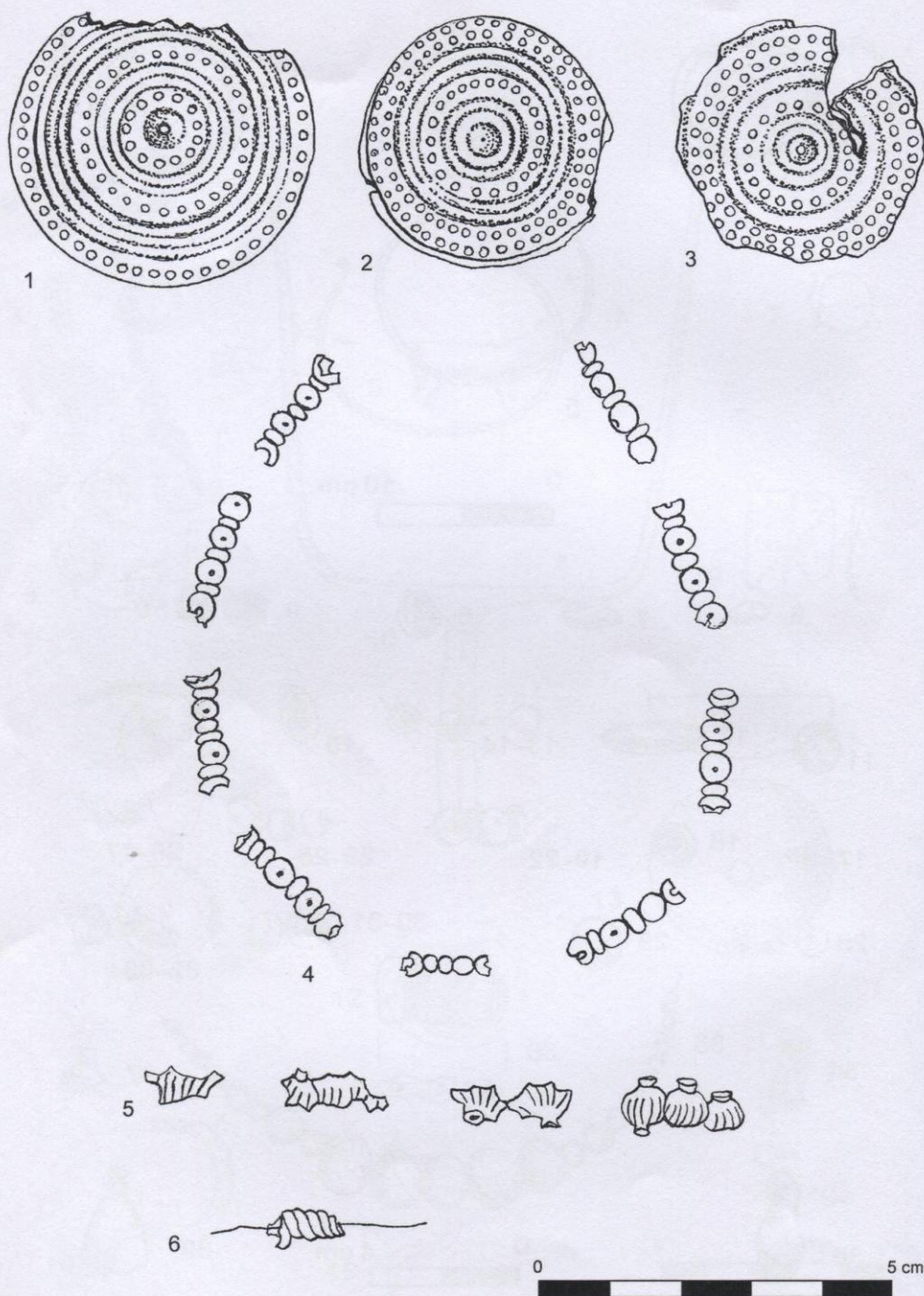


Fig. 9: Gold jewellery from the Atsquri barrow.

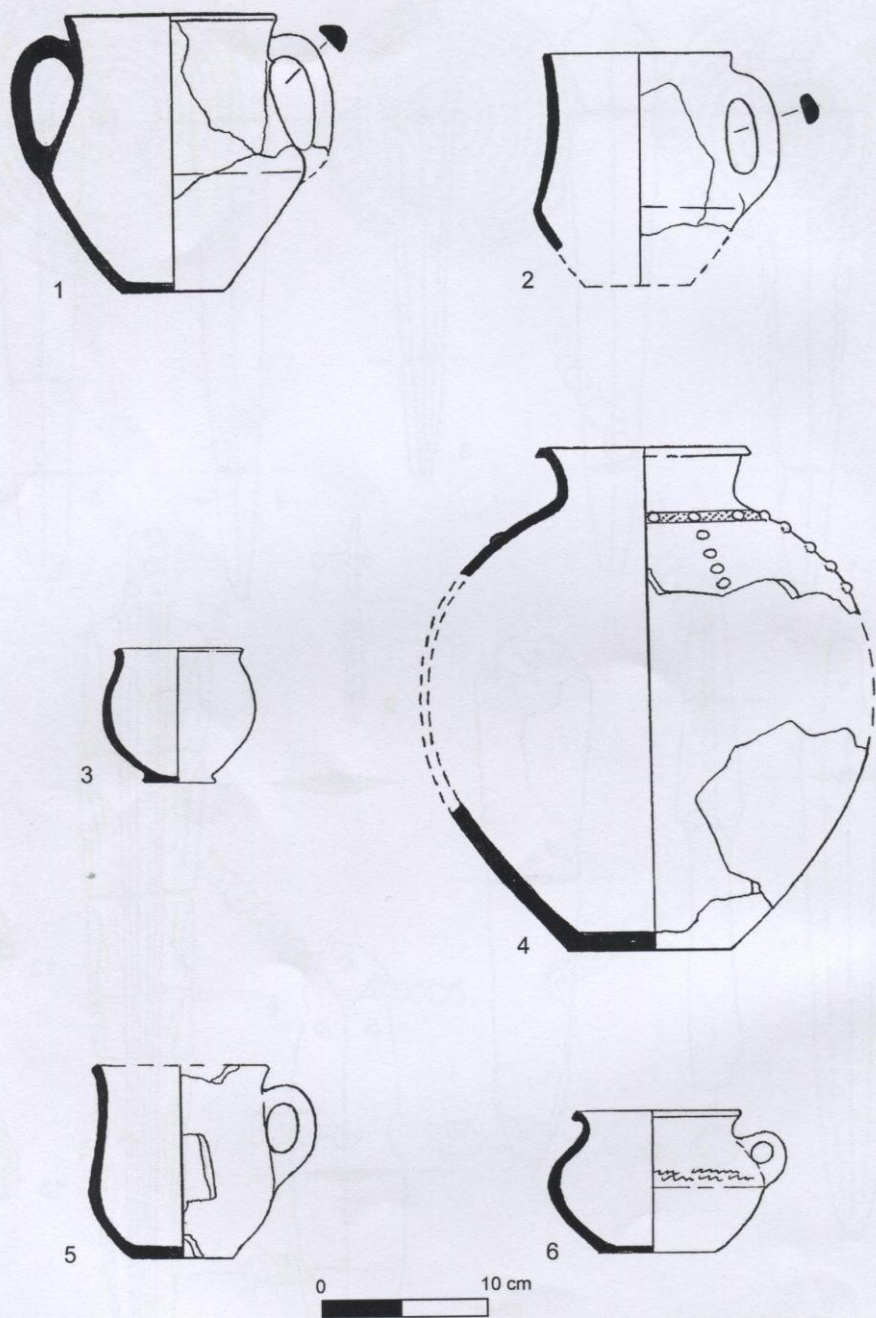


Fig. 11: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

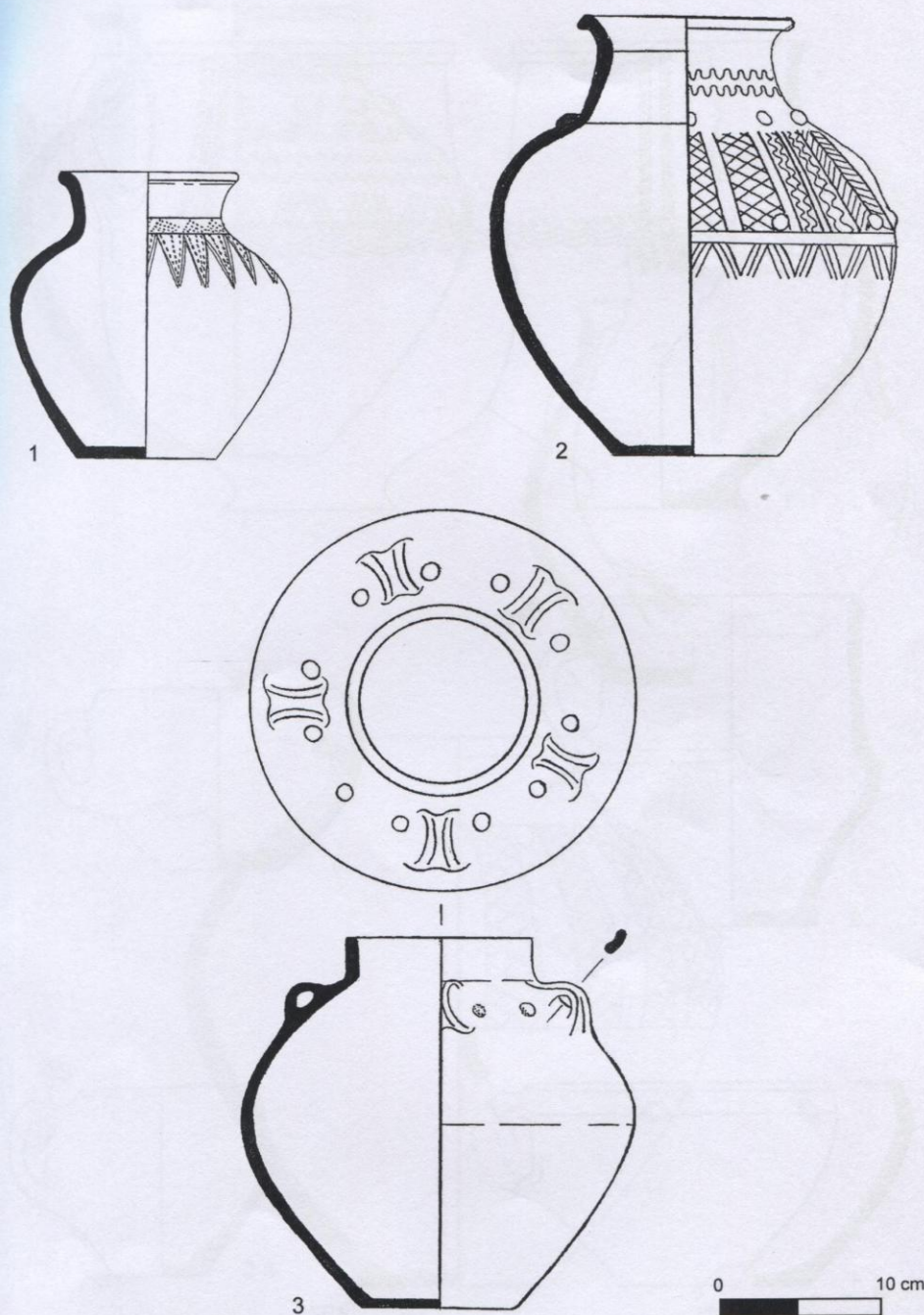


Fig. 12: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

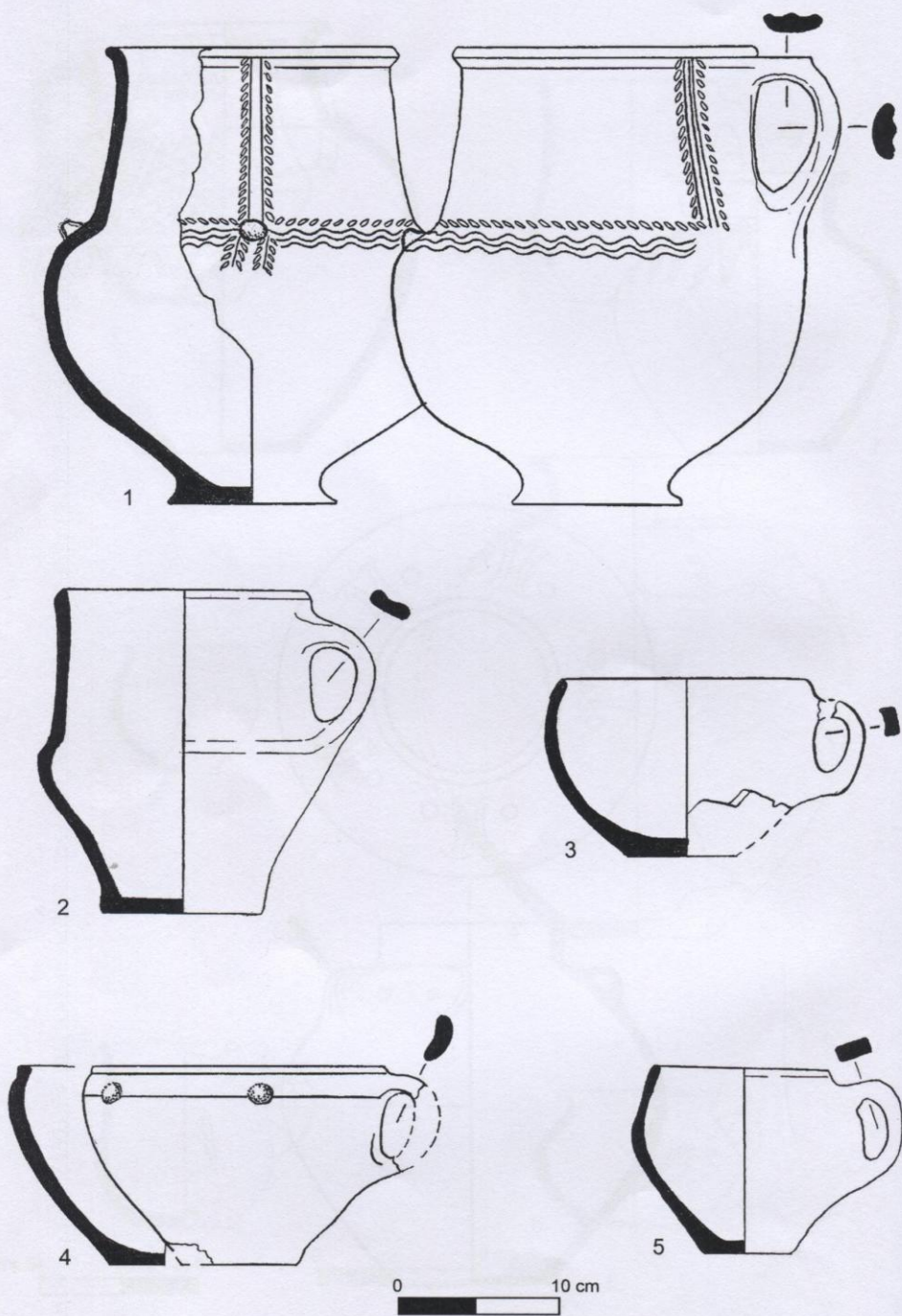


Fig. 13: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

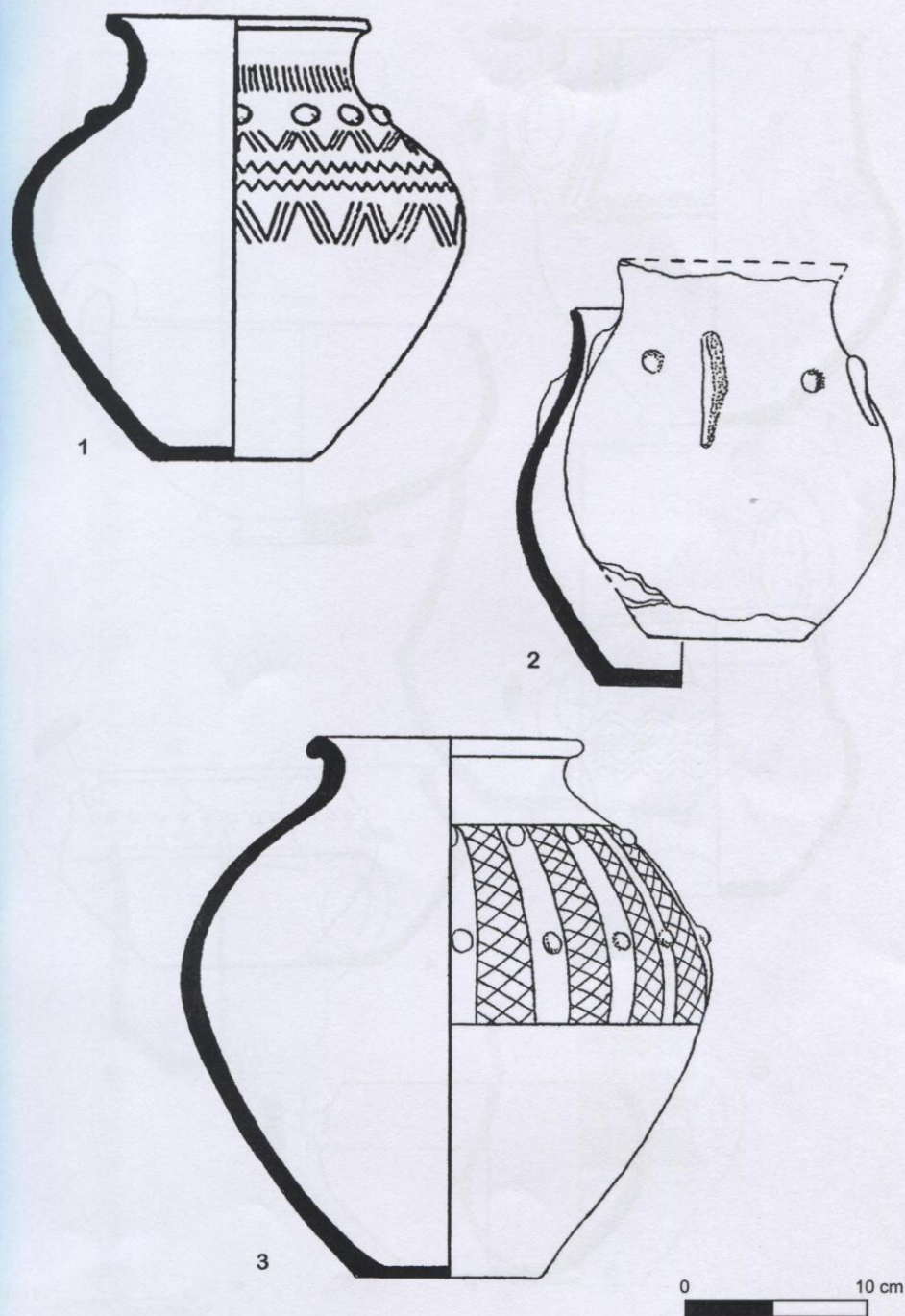


Fig. 14: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

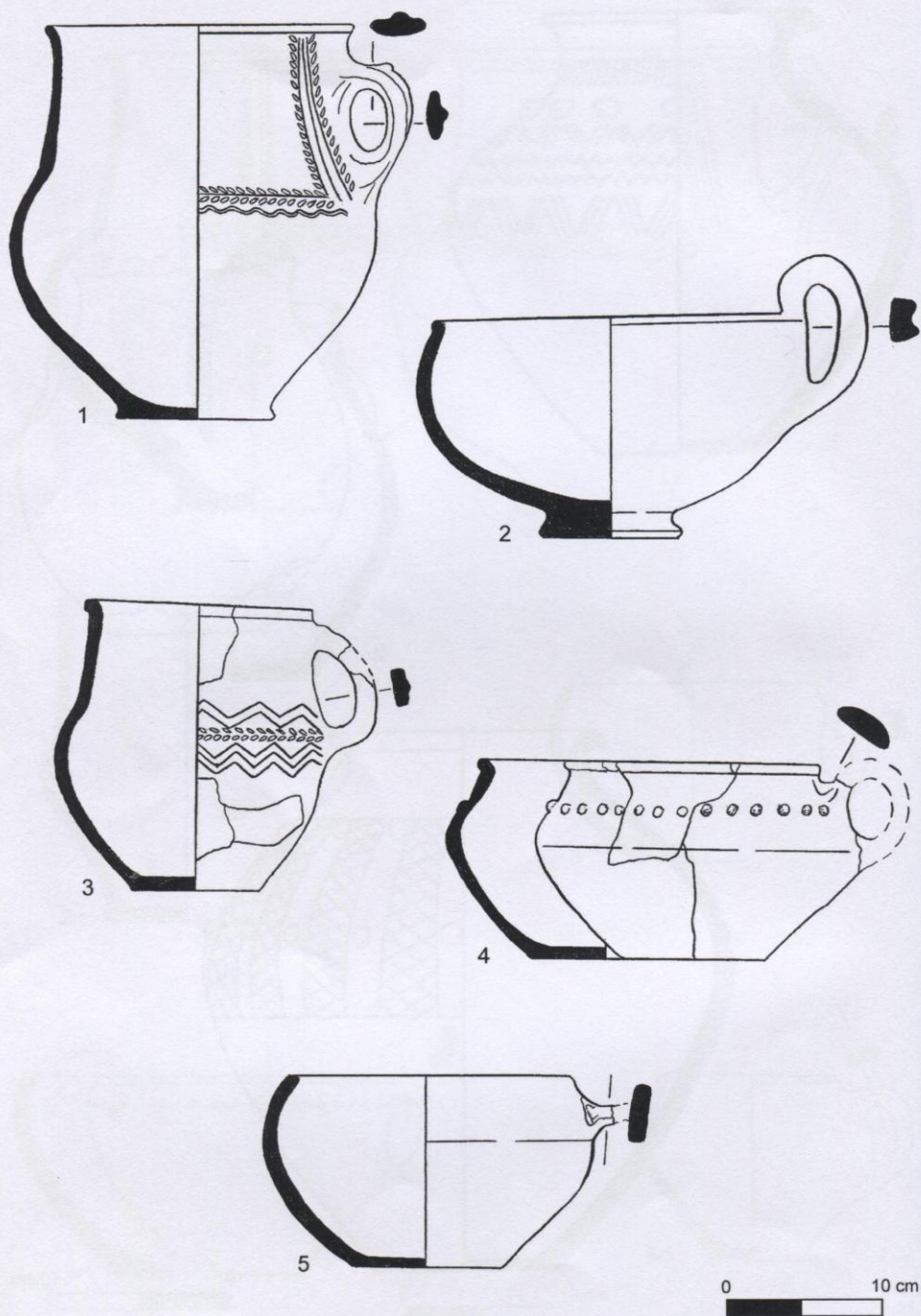


Fig. 15: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

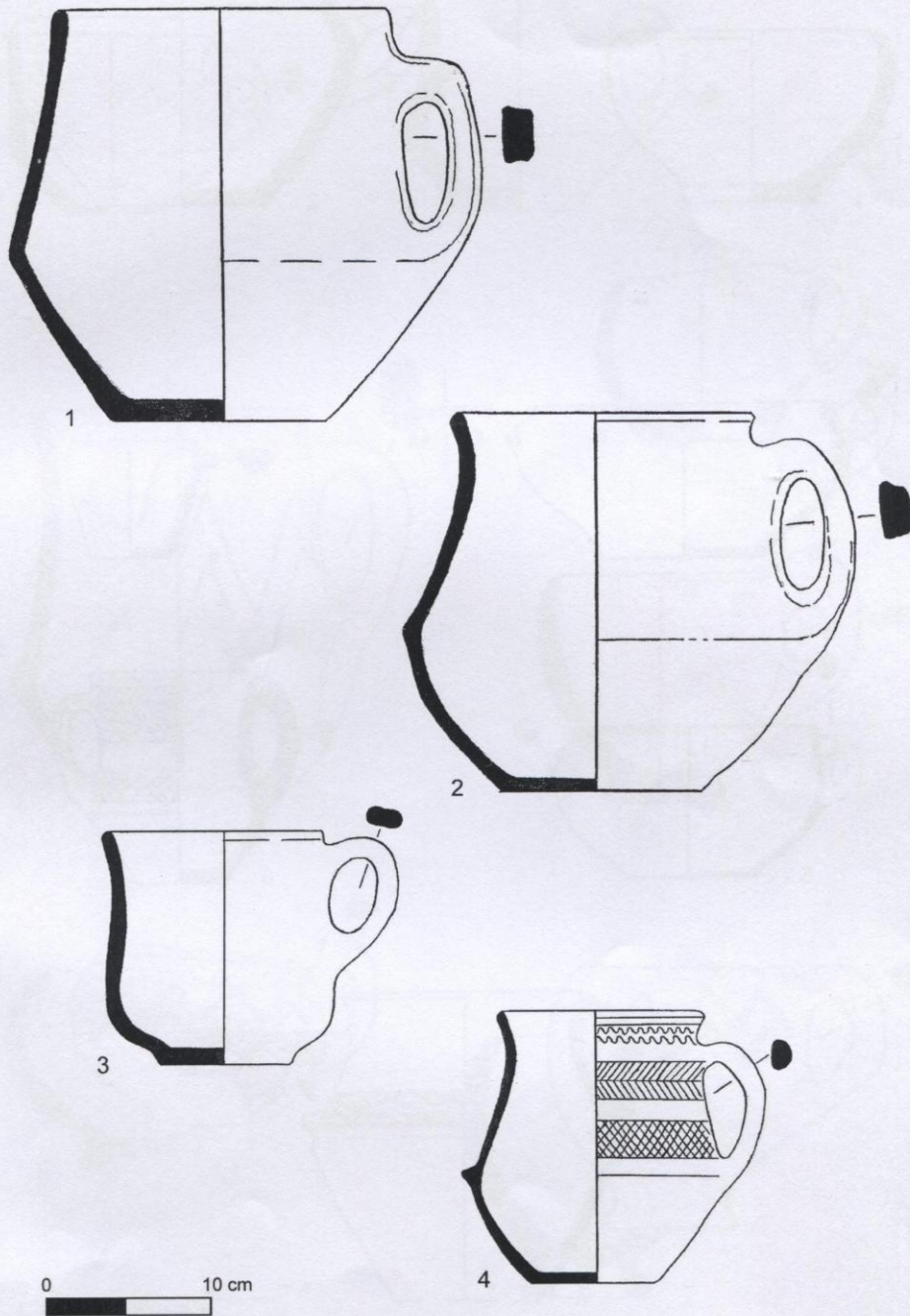


Fig. 16: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

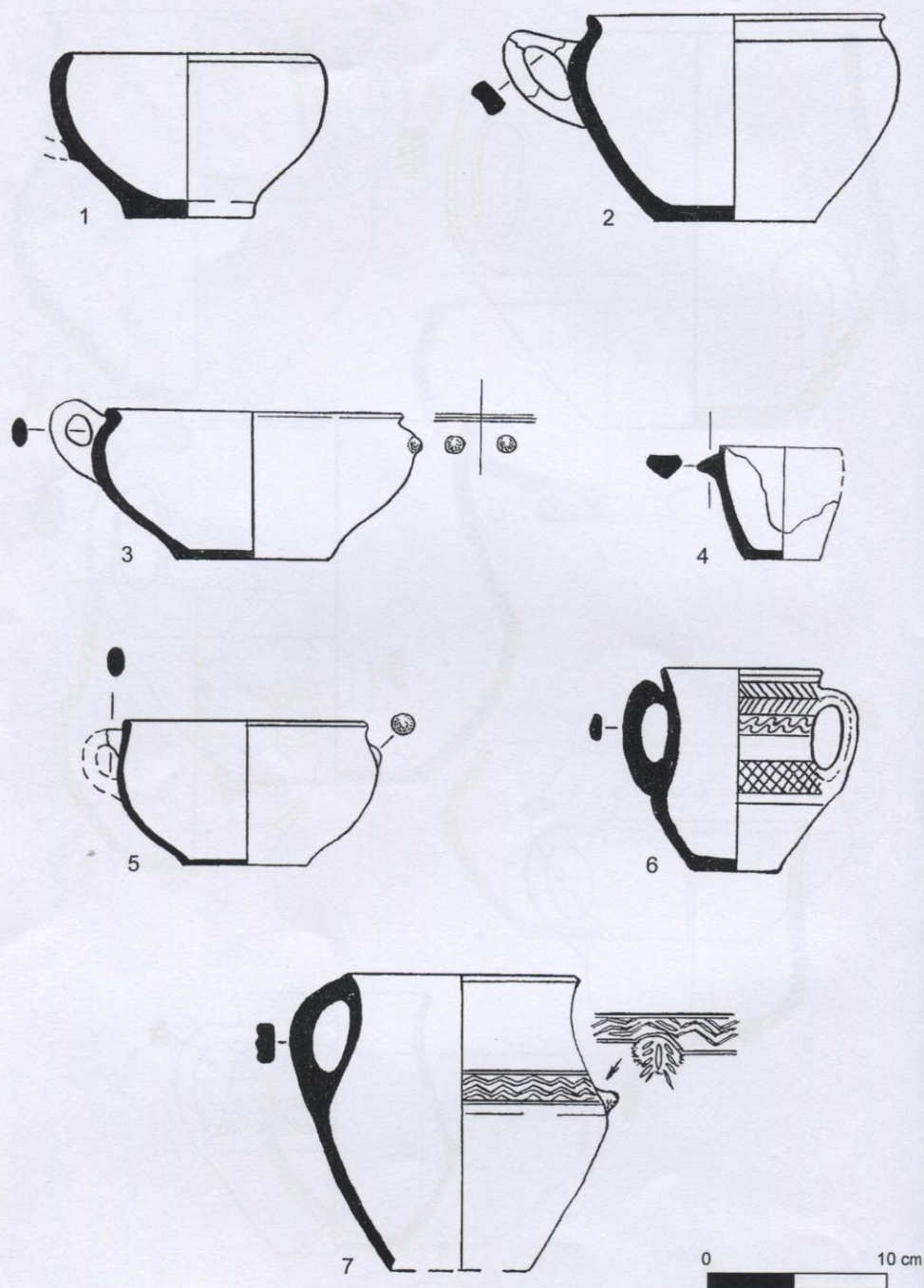


Fig. 17: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

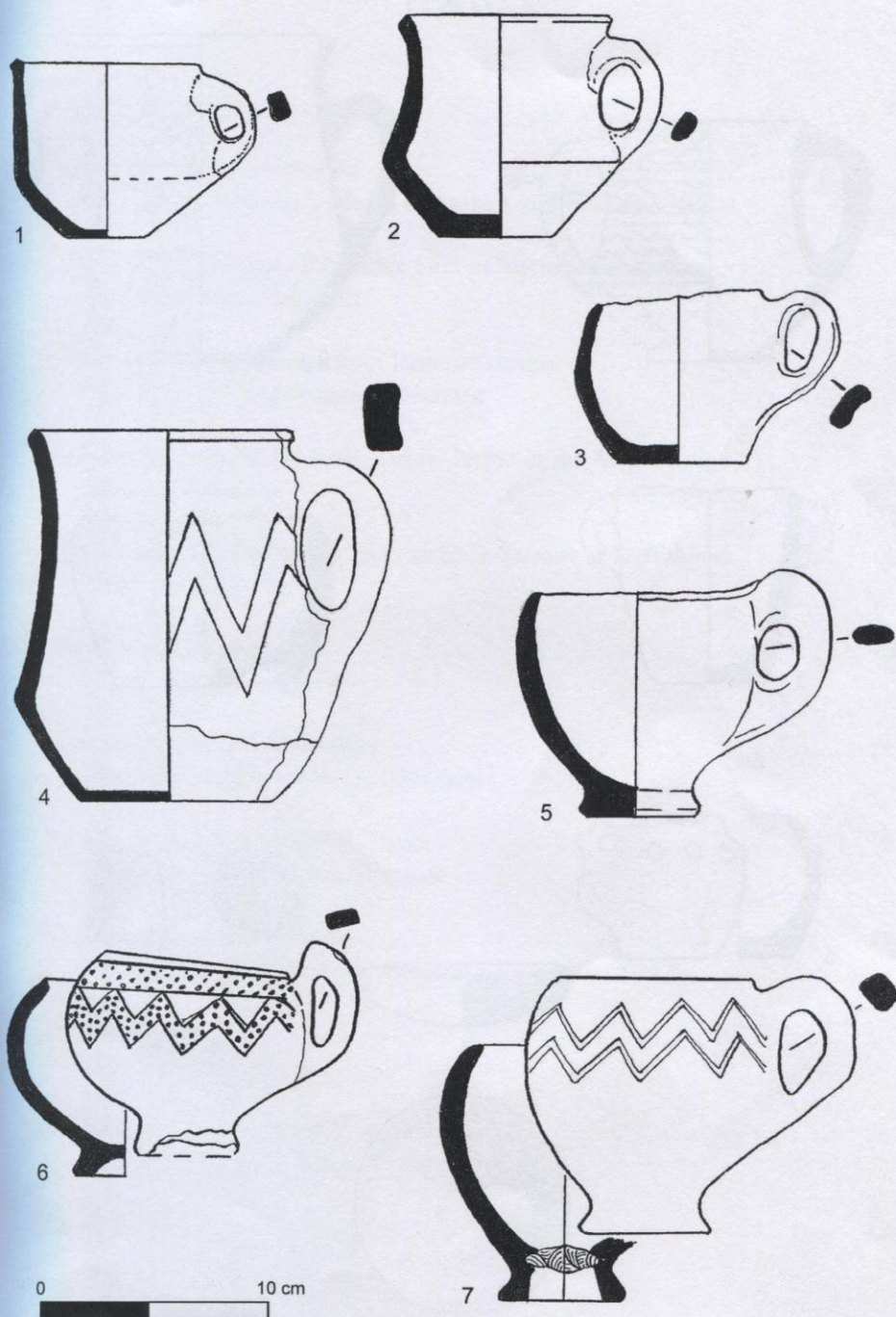


Fig. 18: Pottery from the Atsquri barrow.

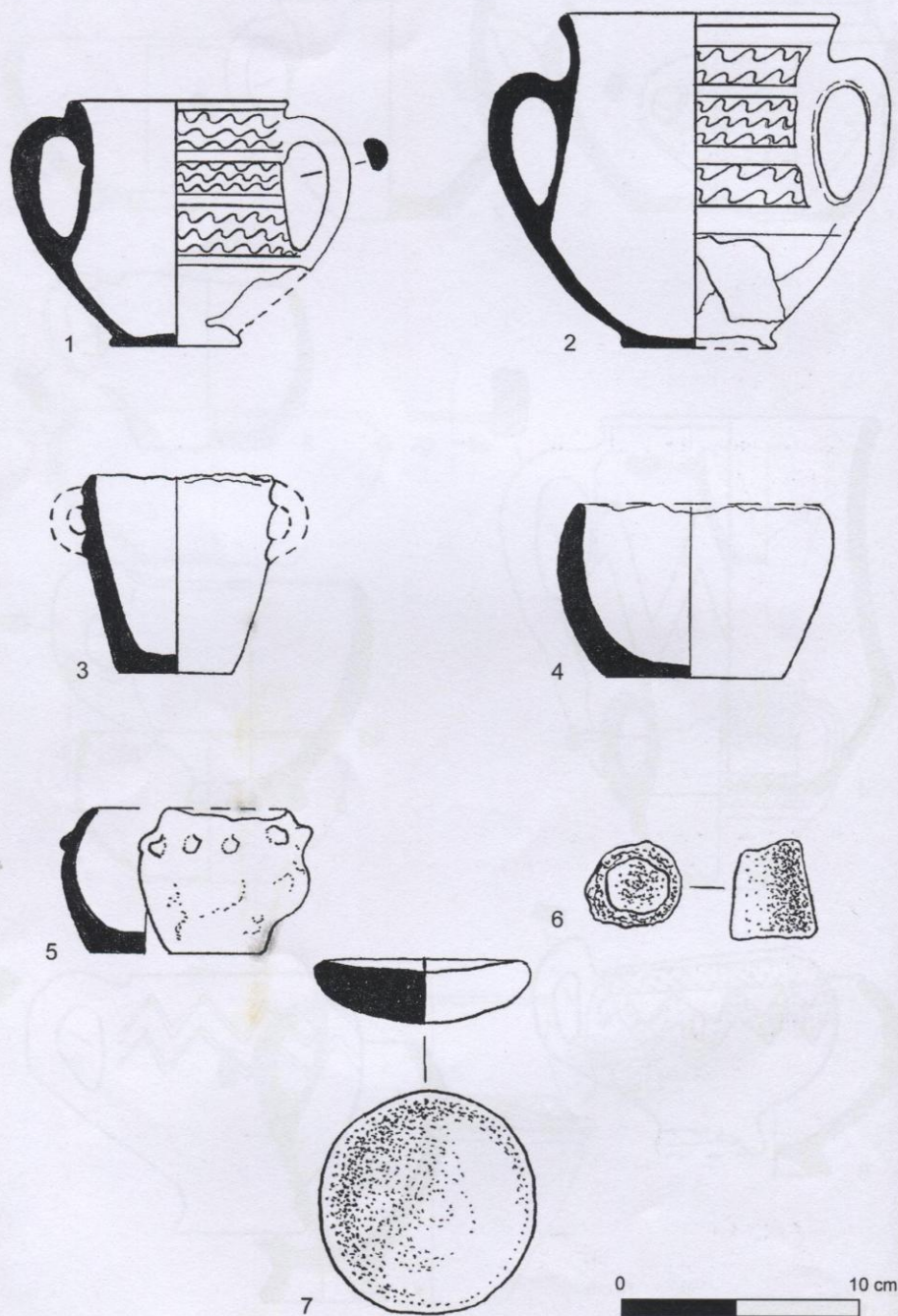


Fig. 19: 1–5. Pottery from the Atsquri barrow; 6. Basalt pounder; 7. Basalt mortar.

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